



WITH OVER 200 EVENTS, EACH WITH LAYERS OF MICRO-PROGRAMMING, EXPERIENCING THE ENTIRE FESTIVAL WON'T BE EASY. "PEOPLE WILL BE FORCED TO TAKE A CALL," SAYS MUNJAL

"We don't say this publicly, but it is probably the largest multidisciplinary festival in the world, with artists from about 30 countries participating. We see some 100,000 footfalls a day," says Sunil Kant Munjal, chairman, Hero Enterprise, of the Serendipity Arts Festival (SAF), which he founded in 2016. The ninth edition of the festival will be held in Panjim, Goa, from December 15 to 22, 2024, and will span everything from the visual arts to music, theatre, dance, culinary arts, craft and more.

The seeds of the mega festival were sown long ago. Munjal, now 66, was inducted into the arts at an early age. As a child he saw Ravi Shankar and Alla Rakha perform in private baithaks at home. At Doon School, the art and music departments were "fantastic", and legendary art teachers like Rathin Mitra kindled an early love of visual art. He started collecting art in the 9th standard with pocket money he had saved, buying artists from the Bengal School, then moving on the Baroda artists and the Progressives. Hardly a typical teenage hobby, but appropriate for someone who would go on to play a pivotal role in promoting the arts.

But before Munjal conceptualised SAF, he established a vibrant cultural festival in home town Ludhiana, where father Brijmohan Lall Munjal had set up Hero Cycles in 1954. The idea behind the Ludhiana Sanskritik Samagam (LSS) was "to inculcate a little bit of culture in an industrial city". LSS celebrated its silver jubilee earlier this year. Seeing its runaway success, friends urged Munjal to start something similar in Delhi. Munjal felt Delhi had a lot going on already. His daughter, Shefali, who is deeply involved in SAF, was a Goa regular and even had a place there—and that swung things in Goa's favour.

One of the reasons Munjal started SAF was to try and expand the scope and reach of the arts to as many people as possible. The other was to focus on the arts as practiced in India historically. "In ancient India, all arts were taught and practiced as one. Otherwise, how can you create something like Ajanta and Ellora?" he muses. "Multi-disciplinarity is at the core of Indianness in creative arts—that's what led to SAF."

The name came, well, serendipitously. Munjal's wife ran a bookstore, Serendipity Books, at the Claridges hotel in Delhi. When the hotel shut down for renovations, they closed the bookstore but retained the name. "It describes exactly what we do—create happy coincidences," says Munjal.

SAF works with a distinguished line-up of curators. This year's curators include Geeta Chandran and Jayachandran Palazhy (dance), Veerangana Solanki and Thukral & Tagra (visual arts), Zubin Balaporia and Bickram Ghosh (music), and Quasar Thakore Padamsee and Sankar Venkateswaran (theatre), among others. "They have a lot of freedom, but we have guardrails on what the festival is about. There's a big push on them working together," says Munjal.

A few miscellaneous highlights from the upcoming edition: 'Sutra', an Odissi dance performance by Sharmila Biswas; 'One World', a concert featuring legendary rockers Lou Majaw, Warren Mendonsa and Pratika Gopinath; 'The Three Divas', a concert featuring iconic vocalists